taking territory and threatening the weak state's nuclear command and control. In this situation, the weak state could delegate launch authority to field commanders or use its weapons before it lost the ability to do so.[26] This risk of inadvertent escalation would threaten to make even small-scale confrontations between new nuclear powers catastrophically costly.

Despite these dangers, however, aggressive behavior by a weak, dissatisfied proliferator would not be irrational. Nor would it necessarily be the result of organizational pathologies that short-circuited strategic decision-making. Rather, destabilizing behavior would be the product of a deliberate strategic calculation. A weak, dissatisfied proliferator would challenge existing territorial arrangements in the belief that its insulation from all-out retaliation, and its ability to attract international attention, would afford it a significant chance of achieving its politico-military goals. This means that nuclear weapons proliferation can be destabilizing quite apart from organizational or other pathologies. The structure of relative military capabilities and territorial preferences within a conflict relationship can also create strong incentives for dangerous behavior.

This is not to argue that all weak, dissatisfied proliferators will behave aggressively. The strength of incentives for aggressive behavior will depend to a large extent on a proliferator's level of dissatisfaction with existing territorial arrangements. The more dissatisfied a state is with current territorial boundaries, the more likely it is to attempt to change them by force. Thus a proliferator that is only mildly unhappy with existing arrangements may not behave aggressively. The level of a proliferator's relative military weakness will matter as well. A proliferator that is only slightly weaker than its adversary is less likely to need a shield against catastrophic defeat, and thus less likely to be emboldened by the acquisition of nuclear weapons, than a proliferator that suffers from a significant conventional military disparity. But despite these caveats, my basic point remains: Territorial dissatisfaction, conventional military weakness, and nuclear weapons are a potentially destabilizing combination.